

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 15 & 16 (Redux)

CHAPTER 15: FATHER MOORE: FIRST CONTACT (REDUX)

Flashback. December 1976.

The hospital chapel was a closet with a stained-glass window.

It was tucked away on the fourth floor, between the oncology ward and the vending machines. It smelled of floor wax, old carpet, and the desperate, silent prayers of a thousand grieving families.

Father Richard Moore knelt in the back pew. The wood was hard against his knees.

He wasn't praying. He was hiding.

He held his rosary in his hands, the beads warm from friction.

Lord, let this cup pass from me.

It was the coward's prayer. He knew that. But he prayed it anyway.

He didn't want to go into Room 304.

He didn't want to see Emily.

Because he knew what was waiting for him.

Not a sickness. Not a broken wire in a brain.

Something else. Something that had looked at him from the shadows of the rectory last night. Something that had whispered his name in the wind.

The door to the chapel opened.

A nurse looked in.

"Father Moore?"

He jumped.

"Yes."

"Dr. Vogel said you can go in now. But only for ten minutes. She's... agitated."

"Agitated," Moore repeated. It was such a clean, clinical word.

"She's biting the restraints," the nurse said. She looked tired. "Just... be careful, Father. She's strong."

Moore stood up. He kissed the cross on his rosary.

"Thank you."

He walked out of the chapel and into the corridor.

The hospital was a machine. Beeping monitors. Hissing oxygen tanks. The squeak of rubber soles on linoleum.

It was a factory designed to fix broken bodies.

But they couldn't fix this.

He reached Room 304.

The door was closed. There was a biohazard sign on it. *Precautionary.*

He pushed it open.

The room was dark. The blinds were drawn, slashing the room with bars of grey light.

The air conditioner was blasting. It was freezing inside.

Emily lay on the bed.

She was tied down. Four-point leather restraints.

She was thrashing. Not violently. Just... writhing. Like a snake pinned under a boot.

"Emily?" Moore whispered.

She stopped.

She turned her head.

Her hair was matted with sweat and saliva. Her lips were cracked, bleeding.

But her eyes...

Her eyes were wide open. And they were black.

Not dark brown. Black. The pupils had swallowed the irises.

"Hello, Richard," she said.

It wasn't Emily's voice.

It wasn't the guttural, demonic voice from the movies, either.

It was a voice he knew.

It was the voice of his old seminary professor. Father Giamatti. A man who had died ten years ago.

"You're late for class, Richard."

Moore froze. The blood drained from his face.

"Who are you?"

The thing in the bed laughed. It was Giamatti's laugh. Dry. Wheezing.

"I am the Lesson."

Moore walked to the bed. He felt heavy. Gravity seemed stronger in this room.

"I command you, in the name of Jesus Christ..."

"Oh, stop it," the voice snapped. It sounded bored. "Save the theatrics for the Bishop. He likes a show. I don't."

Emily's head cocked to the side at an impossible angle.

"You're afraid, Richard. I can smell it. You smell like cheap whiskey and doubt."

Moore stiffened. He had taken a drink before coming here. Just one. To steady his nerves.

"I am a priest of God," he said, his voice shaking.

"You are a bureaucrat in a collar," the voice sneered. "You are a filing clerk for a God who stopped reading the mail a long time ago."

The thing leaned forward, straining against the straps. The leather creaked.

"Do you want to know a secret, Richard?"

"No."

"I'll tell you anyway. Because we're friends."

The voice changed.

It wasn't Giamatti anymore.

It was a child's voice. High. Sweet.

"Father? Father, it hurts."

Moore gasped. "Emily?"

"It burns, Father. The medicine. It's burning me."

"I know, Emily. I know." Moore reached out to touch her hand.

"Why did you leave me?" the child's voice wept. "You left me in the dark."

"I didn't leave you. I'm here."

"You're lying!"

The voice shifted again. A deep, resonant growl.

"He is a liar. He is the father of lies."

The bed began to shake. *Thump-thump-thump.*

The water pitcher on the table rattled.

"Leave her alone!" Moore shouted.

"Make us."

Moore grabbed his stole. He put it around his neck.

"Exorcizamus te, omnis immundus spiritus..."

The thing laughed. It was a sound like tearing metal.

"Latin? You think Latin scares us? We spoke Latin when Rome was a village of mud huts! We spoke Sumerian! We spoke the tongue of the First City!"

Emily's back arched. Her spine bent like a bow.

Her mouth opened.

And a swarm of flies flew out.

Moore stumbled back, covering his face.

They buzzed around him, a black cloud of noise and filth.

"Get out!" he screamed.

The door burst open.

"Code Blue! Code Blue!"

Dr. Vogel rushed in. Nurses. Orderlies.

"She's seizing!" Vogel yelled. "Get him out of here!"

"It's not a seizure!" Moore shouted, batting at the flies. "Don't you see them? The flies!"

Vogel looked at him. "What flies? Get him out!"

Two orderlies grabbed Moore.

He looked back at the bed.

There were no flies.

Just Emily, convulsing on the mattress.

But as they dragged him out, she turned her head.

And winked.

Moore was thrown into the hallway.

He stood there, panting, his heart hammering against his ribs.

He looked at his hands.

There was a dead fly in his palm.

Crushed.

Black ichor smeared on his skin.

He stared at it.

Vogel hadn't seen them. The nurses hadn't seen them.

But it was there.

Proof.

Physical proof.

Moore closed his hand. He put the fly in his pocket.

He walked down the hallway.

He didn't look back.

He needed to call the Bishop.

And he needed a drink.

CHAPTER 16: EXHIBIT B: THE PRESCRIPTION (REDUX)

****[INTERSTITIAL NARRATIVE]****

****DATE:**** Current Timeline (The Trial).

****LOCATION:**** Erin Bruner's Condo.

****TIME:**** 2:14 AM.

Erin sat on the floor of her living room. She was surrounded by islands of paper.

Transcripts. Medical records. Police reports.

She had a glass of wine in one hand and a highlighter in the other.

The only light came from the city outside and a small desk lamp that cast long, sharp shadows across the room.

She was looking for a crack.

A crack in the wall of "Medical Certainty" that Dr. Vogel had built.

She picked up the prescription records.

Exhibit 14.

She had looked at them a hundred times.

Gambrolic. 200mg. 400mg. 600mg.

A standard escalation. Titration.

But tonight... tonight something looked wrong.

She held the paper up to the light.

The handwriting.

Dr. Vogel's handwriting was precise. Block letters. Clinical.

But on the prescription for November 15th... the handwriting changed.

Just slightly.

The loop on the 'G' in Gambrolic was wider. The pressure on the pen was heavier. The ink was darker.

Erin frowned.

She pulled out the nursing logs from the same day.

11/15/76. 14:00. Dr. Vogel visits patient. Patient restraints tightened.

11/15/76. 14:30. Dr. Vogel leaves.

11/15/76. 14:45. Patient screaming. Claims Dr. Vogel "fed her to the wolves."

Erin looked back at the prescription.

She picked up a magnifying glass.

She looked at the signature.

H. Vogel, MD.

There was a tremor in the signature.

A small, jagged spike in the 'V'.

Erin traced it.

It looked like... a heartbeat. An EKG spike.

Or a flinch.

Why would he flinch?

He was writing a prescription for an epileptic girl. It was routine.

Unless he was afraid.

Unless he saw something in that room on November 15th that scared him so bad his hand shook.

Erin grabbed her notebook.

She started writing.

Timeline:

Nov 15: Vogel doubles the dose.

Nov 15: Vogel's hand shakes.

Nov 15: Emily claims he "fed her to the wolves."

Hypothesis: Vogel didn't increase the dose to help her. He increased it to *shut her up*.

He was scared.

He saw something.

What did he see?

Erin looked at the empty chair in the corner of her room.

The Eames chair.

It was empty.

But she felt the cold draft again. The smell of copper.

"What did you show him, Emily?" she whispered.

The air in the room seemed to thicken.

Erin looked back at the paper.

The ink on the prescription...

It looked wet.

She touched it.

It smeared.

Black ink on her finger.

Like soot.

Erin stared at her finger.

The record was six months old. The ink should be dry.

She smelled her finger.

Sulfur.

She dropped the paper.

It fluttered to the floor.

It landed face up.

And for a second, the handwriting didn't say *Gambrolic*.

It said *POISON*.

Erin blinked.

The word was gone. It said *Gambrolic* again.

She scrambled back, hitting the sofa.

"Okay," she breathed. "Okay. That's enough for tonight."

She stood up. She grabbed the wine bottle.

She walked to the bedroom and locked the door.

She left the papers on the floor.

But as she lay in bed, staring at the ceiling, she knew.

She had found the crack.

Vogel wasn't a doctor treating a patient.

He was a man trying to bury a secret.

And the secret was waking up.

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